

ART OF ILLUSION

CREATING DIGITAL ART THE EASY WAY

Want to create great looking digital art? You don't need to buy expensive hardware and software like Maya or Photoshop. The Art of Illusion comes to your rescue.



Part—1

This simple yet very powerful software designed by Peter Eastman and others offers great scripting capabilities. So guys, get ready for a digital ride that might inspire you to create great digital art. This article takes you through an easy exercise to create a simple scene called 'Papaya in the Monastic Cell'.

Getting started

Just download the software from artofillusion.org. The authors offer Linux and Windows versions. The Linux version is as simple to install as is Windows. Once installed, fire it up. You get a simple-looking GUI, with a default camera and a light visible in the centre of the viewport as shown in Figure 1. Don't be misled by the simplicity. Hidden beneath is sheer wizardry. Thanks to the authors, it is not cluttered by too many icons, like other software. On the left, you'll find the icon tool-bar. Although these icons are self-explanatory, I shall offer a quick introduction. The icons in Figure 2, in order, are for *Move*, *Scale*, *Cube*, *Cylinder*, *Polygon*, *Camera* and *Move View*. The ones in Figure 3 are *Rotate*, *Universal Manipulator*, *Ellipsoid*, *Spline Mesh*, *Create Curve*, *Create Light* and *Rotate View*. To the right,

you find the property bar, which is helpful whenever you are either editing or texturing an object in the viewport. It becomes a simple short-cut to the menu items, which are, as usual, arranged at the top.

Creating the profile curves

Click the *Curve* tool, and start adding points to create your first profile curve, as you see in Figure 4. Your profile curve should correspond to the shape of half a papaya, as shown in the same figure. Hide your first curve by selecting it and clicking *Hide Selection* under the *Object* menu. Now go and create the second profile curve for the fruit container or bowl, as shown in Figure 5. Hide this curve in a similar fashion. Make sure you create these curves in the front viewport.

Lathing, tweaking, renaming and clearing

Make sure the first curve is visible by clicking *Show Selection* after selecting the name of the curve visible in the property bar towards the right of the viewport. Select the first curve you created for the papaya, and go to the *Tools* menu and click the *Lathe* entry. A dialogue box pops